



TWO STORIES ABOUT FLYING

English - Class 10 | Complete Comprehensive Study Notes

Story 1: His First Flight

Author: Liam O'Flaherty

About the Author:

Liam O'Flaherty (1896–1984) was an Irish novelist and short story writer known for his sharp observation of nature, animal behaviour, and human psychology. He participated in the Irish War of Independence and World War I, experiences that made him sensitive to themes of fear, survival, and courage. His stories are simple in language but rich in deeper life lessons. He often uses animals as central characters to reflect human emotions and struggles.

Themes and Values

Theme:

- Overcoming fear of the unknown and taking the first step towards independence.
- The importance of motivation, necessity, and family support in personal growth.
- Instinctive learning and the joy of achievement after struggle.
- Courage develops only when one is pushed out of the comfort zone.

Values:

- Facing fears bravely leads to confidence and freedom.
- Parental strictness or clever encouragement is often for our long-term benefit.
- Perseverance and self-belief can help us discover our hidden capabilities.
- Hunger for success (or literal hunger) can drive us to achieve the impossible.
- Celebration of small victories strengthens family bonds.

Characters

Young Seagull: The timid protagonist — fearful, hesitant, and dependent.

Mother Seagull: Intelligent, patient, and psychologically clever; the key motivator.

Father Seagull, Brothers & Sister: Already independent; they represent successful role models.

Summary

The story opens on a high, steep rocky cliff overlooking the vast sea. A family of seagulls has made its home on a ledge there. The two older brothers and one sister of the young seagull have already learnt the art of flying. They fly fearlessly, circling high in the sky, diving steeply towards the sea to catch fish, and enjoying complete freedom. The young seagull, however, is completely different. He is gripped by an intense, paralysing fear of flying. Even though his wings are perfectly developed and ready, he cannot muster the courage to take the plunge off the ledge into the open air.

For the past twenty-four hours, the young seagull has been standing alone on the narrow ledge, watching his family members soar gracefully. He feels deep envy mixed with terror. Whenever he tries to step forward, his heart trembles at the thought of falling into the deep sea below. He tries to convince himself that his wings are not strong enough, though in reality they are perfectly fine. His father and mother have tried many times to encourage and even scold him, but all efforts have failed. His brothers and sister have also called out to him to join them, but he remains frozen in fear.

As night falls, the entire family flies away to sleep on another rock, leaving the young seagull alone, hungry, and miserable. He has not eaten anything for a long time. The next morning, the sun rises brightly. The young seagull sees his mother returning with a fish in her beak. She lands on a rock a little distance away from him — deliberately just out of his reach. She wants to tempt him with food. The young seagull is extremely hungry. He cries out, begs, and pleads with his mother to bring the fish closer, but she remains firm. She stands there holding the fish, forcing him to come to her.

Driven by desperate hunger, the young seagull finally takes a small step forward on the ledge. Suddenly, his foot slips, and he falls off the cliff. For a split second, he is filled with terror, thinking he is going to drown and die. He spreads his wings instinctively to save himself. To his great surprise, his wings catch the air, and he begins to float. Within moments, he realises he is actually flying! He feels an indescribable thrill and joy. He flaps his wings harder, rises higher into the sky, and then dives down fearlessly towards the sea. He screams with pure happiness. He has finally conquered his fear.

His entire family joins him in the air. They fly around him proudly, celebrating his success. The young seagull now understands that fear was only in his mind. Once he took the first step, flying became natural and wonderful. The story ends on a note of triumph, showing how a small push can change everything.

Story 2: The Black Aeroplane

Author: Frederick Forsyth

About the Author:

Frederick Forsyth is a bestselling British thriller writer and former Royal Air Force pilot and journalist. His background in aviation and journalism gives authenticity to stories involving aeroplanes, danger, and mystery. He is famous for meticulously researched adventure and suspense novels. In this story, he combines his flying experience with elements of suspense and the supernatural/unknown.

Themes and Values

Theme:

- Courage, quick decision-making, and presence of mind in crisis.
- The mystery of unseen or supernatural help in desperate situations.
- Limits of science and technology when facing nature's fury.
- Gratitude and faith in the unknown.

Values:

- Staying calm and focused during emergencies can save lives.
- Never lose hope even when all instruments and hope seem lost.
- Help can come from unexpected or mysterious sources.
- Always be thankful for timely assistance.
- Human courage and instinct are more reliable than machines in critical moments.

Characters

Narrator/Pilot: Experienced, confident, but faces a terrifying situation.

Mysterious Pilot of the Black Aeroplane: The unknown saviour who guides the narrator.

Airport Control Room Staff: Represent reality and logic.

Summary

The narrator, an experienced pilot, is flying his old Dakota aeroplane from Paris towards England on a cold, starry night. He is in a happy mood because he is looking forward to spending the weekend with his family in England and enjoying a big English breakfast the next morning. The flight is going smoothly at first. The stars are shining brightly, and there is no sign of danger. He is flying at 6,000 feet with only a few clouds.

Suddenly, the weather changes dramatically. Huge, ominous black clouds appear in front of him like giant mountains. The narrator decides to fly straight into the clouds instead of turning back, hoping to cross them quickly. As soon as he enters the storm, everything turns dark and terrifying. Rain and hail hit the plane violently. His compass stops working, the radio goes dead, and all navigation instruments fail. The plane is tossed around like a toy by strong winds. He has very little fuel left. The situation becomes life-threatening. He realises he might crash.

At this moment of total despair, the pilot suddenly sees a black aeroplane flying just ahead of him. The other pilot is waving at him and signalling him to follow. Though surprised by the strange black plane, the narrator has no choice. He follows desperately. The mysterious pilot guides him skilfully through the dark, stormy clouds for a long time. Finally, the black plane leads him out of the storm. The narrator sees the lights of the runway at the airport below. He feels immense relief and prepares to land. Just as he lands safely, the black aeroplane disappears into the clouds.

After landing, the narrator rushes to the control room to thank the other pilot who saved his life. To his shock, the woman at the control room says there was no other plane flying that night. The radar had shown only his own Dakota aeroplane in the sky.

No black aeroplane was recorded. The narrator is left puzzled and wonders who the mysterious pilot was. The story ends with this intriguing mystery, making the reader think about unseen forces or guardian angels that help us in times of extreme danger.

Moral (in points)

- Fear holds us back, but taking the first step leads to freedom and success.
- Parents use clever methods to help us grow and overcome weaknesses.
- Necessity is a great teacher and motivator.
- Courage is born only in challenging situations.
- In crises, staying calm and following guidance can save us.
- Technology has limits; human instinct and mysterious help can be decisive.
- Always remain grateful for help received, whether visible or invisible.
- Life's greatest joys come after conquering our deepest fears.

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